

My Story Symphony

YEAR 4 ENGLISH - CHARACTER, SETTING AND PLOT TENSION

Name: _____

Date: _____

Learning Intention

I can explain how character choices, setting and events build plot tension.

Australian Curriculum V9: AC9E4LE03

Key Idea / Strategy

GOAL + OBSTACLE + RISK + CHOICE -> TENSION

Worked Example: The Last Lantern

Tahlia crossed the dark campsite carrying the final lantern. The wind grew stronger and the flame shrank. Halfway to the cabins, she heard a branch crack behind her. She stopped. The lantern flickered again.

- Character goal: carry the lantern to the cabins
- Setting pressure: darkness and strong wind
- Tension: the flame may go out; a branch cracks
- Reader question: Will Tahlia reach the cabins safely?

Guided Check

Which detail creates the strongest tension? Why?

Support Box

Look for a goal, danger, delay, secret or difficult choice.

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INDEPENDENT APPLICATION AND EVIDENCE

The Missing Music Box

Eli had promised to return the old music box before the library closed. As he climbed the narrow stairs, the final bell rang below. The lights blinked once. At the archive door, Eli reached into his bag - and found an empty pocket. Footsteps sounded on the stairs. He remembered placing the box beside the atlas table. Eli had to choose: explain what happened now, or race back before the lights went out.

1. What does Eli want to achieve?

2. Identify two details that increase the tension.

3. What choice must Eli make? Why does the reader care?

4. Is Eli racing back a reasonable choice? Justify with evidence.

I Can

- ☐ identify the story focus
- ☐ support an idea with evidence

Parent Tip

Pause before the ending and ask: What could go wrong now?
Which detail made you think that?

BOOK WEEK 2026

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ANSWER KEY AND TEACHING SUPPORT

Suggested Answers

1. Return the old music box before the library closes.
2. Final bell, blinking lights, empty pocket, footsteps or approaching darkness.
3. Explain now or race back; he made a promise and may lose the box.
4. Answers vary; must use evidence and consider safety/responsibility.

Teacher Tip

Track tension on a low-to-high scale. Ask students to connect each rise to a setting detail, event or character decision.

Curriculum Note

Main alignment: AC9E4LE03 - discuss how authors and illustrators make stories engaging by developing character, setting and plot tensions.